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Who were the *Türkmen* of Ottoman and Safavid lands? An overlooked early modern identity

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Abstract: This essay examines the history of the term *Türkmen* in western Asia, and asks how its significance changed with the spread of Ottoman and Safavid power in the early modern era. Although it always maintained its core connotation of uncouth tribes, the meaning of the term became more complex (and at times conflicting) after the Mongol period, a dynamic which this paper highlights by comparing it to the *Oghūz* identity. Poets and court historians developed novel ways of deploying both terms to explain the political dominance of Turkish speakers in the region. When *Türkmen* gained new import as a political label during the Aq Quyūnlū period, it came to have two contradictory connotations: tribal rebellion and the state-building aspirations of the Anatolian *Türkmen* dynasties. Both were marginalized by the subsequent establishment of Ottoman and Safavid power in the 16th century. However, the term continued to be widely used to describe Turkish-speaking tribes in the region, and manuscripts from the Caucasus version of the Köroğlu epic tradition show how it came to represent an autonomous tribal alternative to the new imperial status quo of the 17th century.

Keywords: *Türkmen*, tribe, *Oghūz*, Ottoman, Safavid, Köroğlu

Although scholars have long accounted for the vital military administrative role that Turks played in medieval and early modern western Asia by ruling over the likes of the Iranian Saljūq (1037–1194), Anatolian Saljūq (1075–1308), Mamlūk (1250–1517), Aq Quyūnlū (1378–1501), Ottoman (1299–1918), and Safavid (1501–1722) states, what we know about these Turks in the realms of politics and culture tends to be oriented around a select group who were conquerors and rulers.[1] Our under-

1 In this essay, I use the terms *Turkish* and *Turks* to broadly indicate Turkish speakers to the west of Central Asia – namely Iran, Iraq, the Caucasus, Syria, Anatolia and the Balkans.

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standing of them is limited by the urban and elite origins of the written sources at our disposal.

This predicament is ubiquitous in the study of pre-modern history, and as such hardly unique to the Turks. But it is especially relevant in their case, for two reasons. The first is that the Turkish populations who migrated westward were predominantly composed of rural-dwelling nomads, a group which scholars of Eurasia have long demonstrated to be underrepresented and mis-characterized in written sources.[2] The second is that for many centuries, the Turks who came to constitute the ruling class in western Asia chiefly patronized literary forms and languages which pre-dated their arrival, giving the impression of an even wider gulf between themselves and their nomadic counterparts. As a result, the historical record offers two starkly contrasting images of the Turk, both distorted by biases in the sources: the pious Islamic ruler and the roving nomadic tribesman.

This essay examines the historical usage of a term which was frequently attached to the latter nomadic stereotype, *Türkmen* (Tur. *Türkmen/Türkmān/Terākime*, Pers. *Turkamān/Tarākimah*, hereby Turkmen), to compensate for the disproportionate scholarly attention granted the former. Turkmen was a term adopted to describe Turkish converts to Islam who composed the vast bulk of the nomadic tribal migrants into Iran, Iraq, Syria, the Caucasus, and Anatolia between the 11th and the 14th centuries. Despite its ubiquity in the historical record, the concept has remained marginal in the study of Turkish history because of its ambiguous connotation in the sources and its relative rarity in elite discourses.[3] These are precisely the features which render it productive to examine, owing to how it consistently denoted historical actors who today tend to fall outside of scholarly notions of the "Islamized" Turkish elite. After tracking its history, I show that the term remained relevant in the wake of the establishment of Ottoman and Safavid power in the 16th century by coming to represent a form of resistance to the new imperial order between Anatolia and Iran.

2 Perdue 2005, 7–8; Golden 2011, 4.

3 From the beginning of its use, *Turkmen* was more specific in its tribal connotation than its more generic counterpart, *Turk* in Persian (pl. *Atrāk*, Tur. *Türk/Etrāk*), with which it occasionally overlapped. In the later Ottoman context, for instance, *Türk* could also be pejorative, Yildirim 2008, 355.

Turks, Muslims, or both?

The historiography of the Turks in western Asia is shaped by a ubiquitous binary of nomadism and urban culture. For the sake of simplicity, we can locate scholars who have written on the subject along a spectrum, one end of which emphasizes Turkish engagement with the culture of an urban elite, whereas the other end underscores the Turks as a distinct social and cultural group with significant and enduring nomadic and rural elements. We may call the first the Islamicate approach, and the second the nationalist approach. While these approaches meet and overlap at the center, the ends of the spectrum represent more exclusionary and limited visions of Turkish history.

The Islamicate approach was originally part of a racialized schema in early 20th-century European Orientalism, the purveyors of which depicted the Turks as the saviors of a decadent Semitic civilization (often contending that they did so by allowing for the influence of Christian, Greek, or Persian elements over Arab ones).[4] Scholarship over the past half-century has shed the language of racial determinism and Islamic decline but has held on to the image of Turks, whether Saljūq, Mamlūk, or Ottoman, as vigorous new bearers of a pre-existing mantle of Islamic culture.[5] This is undoubtedly due to the proclivity of Turkish rulers for Persian and Arabic texts, which provided a ready-made alphabet, a vast new lexicon, and a growing selection of genres and literary forms with which the new conquerors could fruitfully engage, and after which the Ottoman and Timurid dynasties could model written Turkish beginning in the 15th century. Marshall Hodgson described this cultural framework by coining the term *Islamicate* – an attempt to divorce culture from religious belief, although he still insisted that this culture emanated from the region between the Nile and the Oxus Rivers.[6] Persian, Arabic, and mainly as derivative of, Turkish manuscripts are the backbone of this Islamicate model.

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4 Lockman describes this approach in the work of Albert Howe Lybyer, H.A.R. Gibb, and Harold Bowen (Lockman 2010, 105, 109); An example of a later and more tempered version of this approach is found in Lewis 1968, 67.

5 An example of the subtle but pervasive tendency depicting the Turks as a receptacle for a pre-formed Islamic culture can be found in articles from The New Cambridge History of Islam (2010). "The Ghaznavid civil administration was…staffed by Persians steeped in the traditions of Persian bureaucracy and Arabic literary culture," Kennedy 2010, 375; "Should the Turks now entering the Islamic east in great numbers be acculturated in Arabic or Persian?" Elton 2010, 502; "Kayqubād's reign marked a great flowering of Muslim culture in Saljūq Anatolia," Leiser 2010, 308.

6 Hodgson 1977, 3.

This approach, however, teaches us little about the great majority of Turks, which is not its stated aim in any case. Most entered the region as mobile nomadic pastoralists, and despite widespread settlement in towns and villages, scholars have not demonstrated a widespread pattern of assimilation to pre-existing urban cultures. Indeed, Turks were immensely successful at preserving their language and, in many cases, their rural and nomadic ways of life. Their language was even adopted by significant numbers of Armenians, Kurds, Greeks, and speakers of various Iranian languages. Yet we have scant historical material with which to reconstruct their experience.

The nationalist approach fills these gaps by insisting on the continuity of a distinct Turkish cultural identity originating in Central Asia and across the Eurasian steppe. This school of scholarship grew out of pan-Turkish thought in the early 20th century and its adherents, who are ubiquitous in Turkish-speaking countries today, are far more inclined to take folklore and popular culture as a legitimate site of scholarly investigation than those of the Islamicate approach. The eminent Turkologist Faruk Sümer's use of popular tales and oral culture in conjunction with manuscript sources is an example of this valuable methodological flexibility.[7] But this approach tends to insist on an ahistorical Turkishness even where it cannot be demonstrated, a characteristic which a recent edition of a commonly used textbook of literature in Turkey exemplified by describing the Anatolian Saljūq state thus: "...the palace was indeed in the position of being a hub in which Turkishness exhibited all of its colors. From the ruler to the lowest ranking palace slave, everybody lived a Turkish lifestyle, and everybody (including the ruler) spoke Turkish and the dominance of Turkish traditions was on full display."[8] At times, the nationalist approach relies on such reconstructions of an unknown Turkish past in order to compensate for the heavily Islamicate character of the earliest Turkish-ruled states.

It is fortunate that we have several examples of scholars who have combined tools from both ends of the Islamicate to nationalist spectrum. Several were early to mid-20th-century academics in the Turkish-speaking world whose intellectual formation preceded the entrenchment of parochial nationalism and was oriented around the twin anchors of pan-Turkism and Islam-oriented multi-culturalism. This group, although it included ardent nationalists with Turanist tendencies such as Fuad Köprülü, Ahmet Zeki Velidi Togan, and Agah Sırri Levend, had come of age during the late imperial period and thus were familiar with the reality

7 For instance, Sümer's tripartitie history of the Oghuz Turks is divided by history, tribal structure, and epic tradition. Sümer 1980.

8 Şentürk and Kartal,75.

that Turks had always mixed with others. But they were chiefly concerned with the painstaking textual documentation of a national cultural narrative which could legitimize a modern Turkish state, and the unique political and cultural nexus that they occupied disappeared with their generation.[9] Unwittingly, they had laid the framework for more facile nationalist approaches.

Subsequent generations of scholars, especially since the end of the 20th century, have effectively challenged both nationalist and Islamicate understandings of Turkish history. Cemal Kafadar has critiqued the former's emphasis on the static and ahistorical national characteristics of the Turks.[10] An important revision to the Islamicate approach has been built on the critical re-examinations of the ways in which court historians retroactively depicted early Turkish rulers as pious Muslims, a line of analysis that has been applied for Ottoman, Saljūq, and Safavid sources.[11] Frequently, though, scholars in these discussions have selectively applied their skepticism about portrayals of Islamic piety to tribal nomadic state-builders and have thus uncritically reified the concept of orthodoxy in so-called classical Islamic societies.

The history of the term *Turkmen* peels away layers of an identity of Turkish speakers which arose in the wake of their migrations across Eurasia. I argue that the label came to bear connotations of tribal power and autonomy which challenge scholarly notions of an Islamicate Turkish past and which represented a notion of popular political legitimacy. Although the Turkmen perspective was eventually marginalized and pushed out of the Ottoman and Safavid political order, it survived in oral tradition, a key clue to the early modern past which historians have overlooked.

The early use of the term

The precise etymology of the term *Turkmen* is unknown. It was first used in the 10th-century ʿAbbāsid context and was quickly adopted by Arabic and Persian authors in reference to Turkish-speaking tribes which had converted to Islam.[12]

9 Their nation-building attitude is apparent in the titles of their works: Togan 1946 (*An Introduction to the general history of the Turks*); Levend 1973 (*The history of Turkish literature*).

10 Kafadar 1995, 75.

11 For a summary of the debate surrounding Ottoman sources, Lowry 2004, "Debate to date," 5–15; for a critique of Saljuq sources, Safi 2006, chapter 1; also, Peacock 2010, chapter 4; for Safavid sources, Bashir 2014, 385–386.

12 Kellner-Heinkele, "Türkmen," *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, 2nd ed., Brill online.

Owing to its nomadic connotations, the label did not have a strong geographic anchor, and in the medieval and early modern periods it was employed for tribes ranging from Anatolia to Central Asia.[13] The different meanings and uses of the term can best be understood by its changing relationship to a close counterpart, *Oghūz* (hereby Oghuz).

ʿAbbāsid geographers had used the term *Ghuzz* in Arabic (an earlier rendering of Oghuz) for a large group of Turkish tribes in the Aral Sea region of Central Asia, first under the power of the Khazar state in the 9th and 10th centuries and later in close proximity to the Iranian peoples in the regions of Khwārizm and Khorāsān. Although the terms Oghuz and Turkmen frequently referred to the same groups, the former did not connote an Islamic identity whereas the latter did. (Occasionally, Turkmen could also signify the Turkic Kārlūks of the Karākhānid Empire.)[14] In *The Compendium of Turkic Dialects* (*Diwān Lughat al-Turk*), an Arabic-language work commissioned by the early Saljūq dynasty in 11th-century Baghdad, Maḥmūd Al-Kāshgharī used the two terms interchangeably or together as one, and described the "Oghūz-Türkmen" as a nomadic tribe in contrast to other "sedentary" groups of Turks.[15] In this early period, there are no signs that the term carried a sense of political prestige.

Beginning in the 12th century and through the Mongol period, a time which coincided with the spread of Persian as a common literary and administrative language across Eurasia, the term *Oghuz* became increasingly obsolete in favor of Turkmen as the chief descriptor of the new arrivals in Iran and the lands farther west. The latter term appeared frequently in the Persian poetry of the period, where a common trait of the Turkmen was as a fierce warrior, formidable in martial skill but lacking in culture. In 12th-century Aẕarbāyjān, the poet Khāqāni acclaimed the "Turkmen's bow,"[16] and Saif Farghānī in 14th century Aksaray,

13 "Tribe" should not be interpreted according to an antiquated sociological notion of kinship relations. Autonomy from state power was a key characteristic of being a tribe in Persian or Turkish linguistic terms. For instance, "ṭāʾifa," which often translates best as tribe, just as strongly conveys the meaning of faction or coalition. For the Iranian context, Richard Tapper writes that the most important feature of the tribe is a "state of mind," "construction of reality," "mode of organization," and "model for action" that is opposed to that of the centralized state. In early modern western Asia, the term also frequently connoted pastoralism. Tapper makes these arguments in a set of articles in edited volumes. Tapper 1983; Tapper 1988; Tapper 1991.

14 Golden 1992, 212.

15 Al-Kāshgharī, *Dīwān* (1982), I, 82, 101; *Ibid*., II, 362–363.

16 Khāqānī, *Dīvān* (2014), qasīdih 194. In this essay, my usage of the term *Aẕarbāyjān* evokes the region's historical geography, which extended farther west and south than the modern nation state but was not bound by a strict notion of language or ethnicity. For references to the modern state, I use *Azerbaijan*.

in central Anatolia, described Turkmen raids as akin to the sudden descent of Azrael, the Angel of Death.[17] Some poets viewed them as uncouth; the bitterness of their manners ruined Khāqānī's appetite, for instance,[18] whereas Awḥadī Marāgheī in 14th century Aẕarbāyjān considered them to be "unthinking" (*bī-fekr*)[19] and naïve country bumpkins easily fooled by thieves.[20]

But frequently the Turkmen was an innocuous pastoralist, characterized by free movement and his relationship to his herds. In 13th-century Konya, Jalāl al-Dīn Rūmī described Turkmen as separate from urban society. An abandoned village, according to him, contained only wolves, sheep, and Turkmen.[21] He also used the Turkmen's close relationship with their well-disciplined herding dogs as a paradigm of moral virtue on more than one occasion.[22] In 12th-century Nishapur, ʿAṭṭār held them up as a noble example of honest conversion to Islam ("so all, as the noble Turkmen/should accept the faith with utmost sincerity").[23]

The Turkmen had become an integral part of Mongol-era life, but poets mainly portrayed them as outsiders to the urban order. This literary representation may have calcified and become static to some degree, but it is also too variegated and complex to write off as a literary trope. The evidence suggests a widespread perception of the Turkmen as socially and culturally distinct from city life in Iran, the Caucasus, and Anatolia.[24]

Oghuz, by contrast, was used less frequently after the 11th century.[25] Andrew Peacock demonstrates that several 12th-century Saljūq court historians such as al-Ḥusaynī, al-Nīshāpūrī, and al-Rāvandī used the term with negative overtones of disruptive hordes, as did others unassociated with the court such as Ibn al-Athīr.[26] Gradually, assigning the term a pagan connotation, they turned it into a tool for explaining the pre-Islamic past of the Turks. Terms such as Turkmen

17 Farghānī, *Barg* (1996), qasīdih 58.
18 Khāqānī, *Dīvān* (2014), qasīdih 152.
19 Marāgheī, *Dīvān* (1961), 599.
20 Marāgheī, *Dīvān* (1961), 645.
21 Rūmī, *Kullīyāt* (2002), ghazal 2008.
22 Rūmī, *Maṣnavī* (2017), section 1, part 40, heading: "'Etāb kardan-i ātash rā ān padishah-i juhūd"; *Ibid*. section 5, part 129, heading: "meṣl-i sheyṭān bar dar raḥmān."
23 ʿAttār, *Manṭiq* (2014), section, "'Uzr āvurdan-i murghān," subheading "Guftār-i 'Abbāse dar bāri-yi nafs."
24 Ibn Baṭṭūṭa (1304–1369), too, mentioned Turkmen in Syria and Anatolia in their capacity as pastoralists; Ibn Baṭṭūṭa, *Riḥlah* (1987), I: 92, 99.
Yildirim also references a late-14th or early-15th century Anatolian manual of law, the *Kitab-ı Gunya* (sic) by İmam Kadı, which characterized Türkmen as rural, illiterate, and brutish, Yildirim 2015, 293.
25 Cahen/Deverdun/Holt, "Ghuzz," *EI*², Brill online.
26 Peacock 2010, 50–52.

or *Saljūq* remained more neutral and flexible, and came to replace Oghuz for describing groups in the present tense. This new historical usage of Oghuz also establishes the basis for its use in a celebratory and nostalgic sense in the subsequent period.

Turkmen and Oghuz in the post-Mongol period

In the 15th century, there were two important changes in the use of the term *Turkmen* which reflected the rise of Turkish-ruled bureaucratic empires stretching from the Balkans to Central Asia. The first was that the label was no longer a catch-all descriptor for Turkish speakers which emphasized their nomadic ways, but instead acquired a more specific connotation of tribal elements who were resistant to the centralized political projects of the post-Mongol era. These new states were controlled by a Turkish ruling class, and Turkmen was one of the names they commonly used for those tribal elements who fiercely opposed their imperial ambitions.

This pattern is clearest in the case of the Ottomans and their eastern rivals, notably the dynasties of Karamān (1256–1487), Dhūlḳadir (1337–1522), the Qarā Quyūnlū (1374–1468), and the Aq Quyūnlū (1378–1501). These federations relied on tribal militaries who resisted the centralizing forces of Ottoman bureaucracy, especially the latter's exploitation of settled agriculture through a tax system based on cadastral surveys, its use of a professional standing army, and its rotating system of centrally appointed provincial administrators.[27] According to the late 15th-century Ottoman historian Aşıḳpāşāzāde, the Ottoman army jeeringly called the fleeing Aq Quyūnlū ruler Ūzūn Ḥasan and his allies from the Karamān dynasty "lowly Turkmen" (*devletsiz Türkmān*).[28] Rıza Yıldırım has shown how Ottoman court historians and religious scholars distinguished between *Türk* and *Türkmen*, frequently using the former for loyal sedentary subjects and the latter for nomadic tribes who "resisted against the Ottoman regime," especially the Karamānids.[29] Some, though, such as the historian Kemālpāşāzāde (1469–1536), also used *Türk* in the same derogatory manner for dissident tribal elements.[30] Still, the distinction between the two seems to have become more important in the 15th century; when Ibn Baṭṭūṭa passed through Ottoman western Anatolia a

27 İnalcık 1954.
28 Aşıḳpāşāzāde, *Tevārīh* (1913/14), 180.
29 Yıldırım 2008, 138, see also 135–140.
30 Yıldırım 2008, 305.

century earlier, he used the term *Turkmen* as a descriptor for both tribal pastoralists as well as the early Ottoman rulers.[31] As Ottoman institutions became more powerful, tribalism became synonymous with disloyalty.

One of the most successful anti-Ottoman tribal coalitions had gathered under the *Ṣafaviyyah* sheikhs from the city of Ardabil in Aẕarbāyjān, leaders of a Sufi order which acquired a militant character from the 1450s down to the founding of the Safavid state in 1501 and its subsequent conquest of Iran.[32] Even though the movement gained widespread support among Turkish tribes in Anatolia and Aẕarbāyjān, the Ottomans referred to them and their followers as "the Sufis of Ardabil," during this period, owing to their reverence for the sheikhs.[33] Ideology and charisma, then, likely had a major impact on who was labeled Turkmen.

A collective study of Mamlūk, Shirvānshāh, Ottoman, and Timurid sources would yield a more detailed sense of this narrowing of the meaning of the term in the late 14th and early 15th centuries. For instance, was there ambiguity about who was considered Turkmen? In his *Ẓafarnāmih*, composed in the 1420s, the Timurid historian Sharaf al-Dīn ʿAli distinguished explicitly between Turks and Turkmen and emphasized the incivility and rebelliousness of the latter, but painted with a broad brush when he wrote that "most of the inhabitants of Rūm are of that group."[34] It is likely that the distinction between Turk and Turkmen became increasingly convenient in the 15th century for the Ottoman and Timurid political projects, although they presumably applied the terms differently.

The second important change in the post-Mongol period was the claiming of the Turkmen identity as the legitimate basis for a state-oriented political model. This was an unprecedented development which conflicted with the typical derogatory usage of the label in an exclusively tribal sense. The main example of this is the Aq Quyūnlū dynasty. In the chronicle *Kitāb-i Diyārbakriyye*, written in 1470, the historian Abū Bakr Ṭihrāni recounts a vicious and bloody battle with the Qarā Quyūnlū in which the ruler of the latter, Qarā Yūsuf (r.1388–1420), eventually sent a plea to his counterpart reading, "We are both Turkmen peoples [*mā har dū mardom-i turkamānīm*], we do not strive to conquer one another more than this, and we do not call out [for battle] against one another further than this, and each of us should busy ourselves with our Rūmī [Ottoman] and Chaghātāī [Timurid] foes – for you, attacking the inhabitants of Shām [the Levant] and Rūm, and

31 Ibn Baṭṭūṭa, *Riḥlah* (1987), I: 314, 315.

32 Mazzaoui 1972, 71–82.

33 Baltacioğlu-Brammer 2019, 47.

34 Yazdī, *Ẓafarnāmih* (2008), 711. Here, Rum signifies the former Byzantine lands of Anatolia under Ottoman power. For other quotes on the unruly nature of the Turkmen, see Ibid., 706, 760, 840.

for me to battle against the Chaghātāī."[35] Qarā Yūsuf distinguished both of the Turkmen dynasties from the Ottomans by inserting the latter into the Byzantine Roman legacy of Anatolia, and from the Timurids by using the name *Chaghātāī* to acknowledge the Timurid Chingissid Turkic claim over Central Asia and Iran (*Chaghātāī* had, in any case, long referred to a Turkish dialect distinct from those of the Oghuz/Turkmen).

Ṭihrāni employed the term *Turkmen* on several occasions to describe both the Qarā Quyūnlū and Aq Quyūnlū armies. Although its intended meaning stayed within the military realm, he assigned it the more docile connotation of organized support of dynastic rule. He described how the people of the realm of the Shirvānshāh dynasty abandoned their borderland towns for "fear and awe of the Turkmen army" (*az mahābat-i lashkar-i Turkamān*),[36] and how "ten thousand Turkmen warriors" joined the Aq Quyūnlū forces.[37] The *Tarīkh-i ʿĀlam-ārā-yi Amīnī*, a later Aq Quyūnlū chronicle written after the empire's vast eastward expansion, described its military force as "the Turkmen and Chaghātāī people," signifying an incorporation of the latter element into the dynasty's army but retaining a separate Turkmen component.[38]

Admittedly, this was only a hesitant reclamation of the term *Turkmen*. The descriptor appears to be predominantly military in character, and is not used in reference to the Aq Quyūnlū dynasty or origins. Moreover, Ṭihrānī's usage of the term did to some degree overlap with the more negative and wild portrayal of Turkmen in Ottoman sources, despite his repurposing of it. He was well aware of its tribal connotations, for instance, when he wrote about enemies in Qazvin who "fell into the claws of the beasts of the Turkmen, Kurds, and Lors…like creatures of the jungle," referring to an Aq Quyūnlū force outside of the city.[39]

There was good reason for Aq Quyūnlū historians to be more receptive to tribal terminology than their Ottoman neighbors. The dynasty ruled over an elastic political structure which offered appealing autonomy to tribes and nomads across Anatolia and Iran, especially in comparison to more centralized Ottoman institutions.[40] It also gave shelter to the early Safavid movement for a period, sharing its emphasis on *ghazā* (religiously charged warfare against Christian societies) and a reliance on tribal military power. But by the late 15th century, the Aq Quyūnlū project had spawned a bureaucratic state with pretentions to uni-

35 Ṭihrānī, *Kitāb* (1964), 58.
36 Ṭihrānī, *Kitāb* (1964), 374.
37 Ṭihrānī, *Kitāb* (1964), 471.
38 Khunjī-Isfahānī, *Ālam* (2003), 175.
39 Ṭihrānī, *Kitāb* (1964), 505.
40 Woods 1999, 28.

versal rule, and the dynasty attempted to snuff out the Turkmen-driven Safavid project which it had earlier sponsored.[41] Their historians' conflicting use of the Turkmen label may have reflected their own changing relationship with their tribal military base.

Despite differing attitudes towards Turkmen identity, the Ottomans, the Aq Quyūnlū, and the Qarā Quyūnlū were unified in adopting an approach to the Oghuz identity which relegated it to the realm of history and legend. The Ilkhānid historian Rashīd al-Dīn Hamadānī (1247–1318), in *The Compendium of Chronicles* (*Jāmiʾ ul-Tavārīkh*), was the first to deploy the legendary figure of Oghūz Khān as an Islamic convert and progenitor of the Saljūqs and the Turks of the Ilkhānid realms more broadly.[42] Rashīd al-Dīn's codification of the Oghūz Khān warrior legend became the basis of a textual tradition which scholars refer to as the *Oghūznāme* (i. e. the Book of Oghuz) based on 14th-century nomenclature, mainly constituting a set of texts which were used in the following centuries to legitimize Turkish rulers.[43]

The *Oghūznāme* tradition emerged from the urgent need for court historians to create new structures of legitimacy for Turko-Mongol rulers who could not reasonably claim ties to the Prophet Muhammad, charismatic Islamic figures, or conquerors such as Chingīz Khān. The Oghūz Khān narrative became a standard passage of Ottoman genealogies in the 15th and 16th centuries and was also featured in both Aq Quyūnlū chronicles.[44] This lore also circulated in the oral realm via the Book of Dede Korkut, an episodic storytelling tradition mainly attributed to the early Aq Quyūnlū period which portrayed the Oghuz as an idealized tribal society of the past. It told tales of Oghuz raids against their Christian neighbors in service of leaders called by the Turkic label *khān*.[45]

An origin story of a charismatic tribal warrior was a perfectly acceptable legitimizing tool for the Ottomans, despite the urban and bureaucratic character of their state. But there are signs that the Aq Quyūnlū and Qarā Quyūnlū considered themselves, and were considered by the Ottomans, more authentically Oghuz. John Woods argues that the Aq Quyūnlū viewed themselves as the bearers of the Oghuz legacy, and as such incorporated this notion into their anti-Ottoman political propaganda.[46] Meanwhile, in 1458/59, the Ottoman historian Şükrullah depicted the Qarā Quyūnlū as the chief transmitters of a shared Oghuz heritage.

41 Woods 1999, 108–109.
42 Kamola 2015.
43 Fuzuli 2016, 375.
44 Bİnbaş 2010.
45 Tezcan and Boeschoten 2018.
46 Woods 1999, 27, 56.

According to him, the ruler Cihān Şāh (r.1438–1467) explained to an Ottoman emissary in 1449 that the two states were of the same Oghuz lineage, and even showed a book "written in Mongolian" as proof of this fact.[47] For the eastern Anatolian dynasties, the *Oghūzname* tradition was more directly relevant to their Turkmen political identity, and thus their claim to legitimacy, than it was for the Ottoman dynasty.

The 16th century brought the gradual partitioning of western Asia between the Ottomans and the Safavids and an end to self-proclaimed Turkmen political power. The legacy of the Anatolian dynasties of the 15th century, however, had served to elevate the Turkmen name, and further aided its repurposing even after their fall from power. Safavid chronicles in this century designated the Aq Quyūnlū and Qarā Quyūnlū as the "Turkmen Sultans" (*Salāṭin-i Turkamān*)[48] and frequently added the label *Turkamān* to the names of rulers, giving the term the effect of an honorable title.[49] The first self-consciously Kurdish historian Sharaf Khān Bidlīsī (1543–1603), who was familiar with Ottoman and Safavid historiography, in 1597 referred to these dynasties as Turkmen, or employed the common plural, *tarākimah*.[50] The terminology was still fluid, though; the historian Khwāndamīr of Herat (1475–1534), who was still entrenched in the Timurid historiographical tradition, in 1524, used the term *Turkmen* for animal herders in contrast to a more sweeping usage of the term *Turk* for political rulers, much as the Sharaf al-Dīn ʿAlī had a century before.[51] In 1555 in Qazvin, one Safavid historian described the Aq Quyūnlū and Qarā Quyūnlū rulers as "Turk Kings" (*Pādeshāhān-i Turk*) alongside the individual label *Turkamān*.[52] The contradiction between the tribal and state-oriented meaning of the term remained, although it seems to have gained a measure of political legitimacy.

With regards to their own history, Safavid historians did not use the term *Turkmen* derisively, but instead attached to it a raw military function. For instance, Hiravī referenced the role of the Turkmen in gathering around the first Safavid ruler Shāh Ismāʾīl I (r.1501–1524) in Erzincan in 1500, whereas other 16th-century historians avoid the term when narrating this famous episode and instead named the specific tribes who participated.[53] In 1570, one court historian used the phrase, "*Qūrchiyān-i ʿuzzām-i Turkamān*," that is, "the grand Turkmen

47 Atsız Çiftçioğlu, *Osmanlı Tarihleri*, 51.
48 Shīrāzī, *Takmilat* (1989), 36, 38.
49 Rūmlū, *Aḥsan* (1977), 11; Al-Qazvīnī, *Lubb* (1936), 211.
50 Bidlīsī, *Scheref-nameh* (1860), I: 310; *Ibid*., II: 55 (two of several other examples).
51 Khwāndamīr, *Ḥabīb* (1984), 887, 988, 1017.
52 Al-Qazvīnī, *Lubb* (1936), 211.
53 Hiravī, Futūḥāt (2004), 101.

royal guard," to describe the palace military unit.[54] Shahzad Bashir has shown how Safavid historians refashioned the term *Qezelbāsh*, originally a descriptor of the early Turkmen coalition which had supported the Safavid house, into a charismatic label which emphasized the mystical origins of the dynasty within the *Ṣafaviyyah* Sufi order of Aẕarbāyjān together with its official policy of Twelver Shiʿism.[55] This narrative of Safavid legitimacy obscured the ambitions of its early tribal constituents: political autonomy, freedom from state intervention, and charismatic messianism rooted in the cult of ʿAlī.[56] The chronicles did not emphasize a shared Turkmen identity in Shāh Ismāʾīl's coalition and oriented the dynasty's message away from their tribal ethos.

Elsewhere, the Turkmen label and legacy remained ambiguous in the wake of the establishment of Ottoman and Safavid power. Aṛak'el of Tabriz, a 17th-century Armenian historian, referred to the Qarā Quyūnlū ruler Cihān Şāh as "the great king [*patshah*] of the Turkmen."[57] The Ottoman traveler Evlīyā Çelebī, a contemporary of Aṛak'el's, used the phrase *āl-i Turkmāniyān* (the Turkmen dynasty) to describe both the Dhūlḳadir dynasty as well as the early Mamlūks, giving the name an air of dynastic legitimacy.[58]

There is, however, a revealing detail in Evlīyā's description of the Aq Quyūnlū which suggests how fraught the term remained. Although he held the Aq Quyūnlū ruler Ūzūn Ḥasan (r.1457–1478) in great esteem, lionizing him as the *Sulṭān* and *Şāh* of Aẕarbāyjān and referencing him on dozens of occasions, he did not refer to him or his followers as Turkmen.[59] Elsewhere, he used the term frequently: he habitually used the word *Turkmānistān* to refer to a region which overlapped with *Kürdistān* in eastern Anatolia, regularly described anonymous Turkish tribes across Anatolia and Iran as Turkmen, and on several occasions employed the phrase "the devious Turkmen" (*Türkmen eşirrāsı*), a descriptor he also paired with tribal Kurds (*Ekrād*), Arabs (*ʿUrbān*), and Turks (*Etrāk*).[60] We can speculate that for Evlīyā, who was deeply committed to the Ottoman imperial project, the contradictions of the Turkmen label and its connotations of unruliness rendered it unfit for the great sovereign of Aẕarbāyjān.

54 Shīrāzī, *Takmilat* (1989), 83.

55 Bashir 2014, 385–386.

56 Mazzaoui 1972, 73.

57 Aṛak'el, *Book* (2010), 330; for the Armenian text, see Aṛak'el, *Patmutʿiwn* (1884), 326.

58 Evliya, *Evliya* (2006), book 3, 101; *Ibid*., book 10, 32–33.

59 Evliya, *Evliya* (2006), book 2, 126–129, 163; *Ibid*., book 4, 94.

60 For *Turkmānistān*, Evliya, *Evliya* (2006), book 2, 194; *Ibid*., book 4, 12, 14, 31; Evliya wrote about summer pastures around Erzurum and Adana that, "If I were to list all of the Turkmen tribes and clans here, that would require another tome!" Evliya, *Evliya* (2006), book 3, 29; for *Türkmen eşirrāsı*, Evliya, *Evliya* (2006), book 3, 35, 87, 98.

Köroğlu, the Turkmen

Thus far, we have seen that the concept of the Turkmen was either used pejoratively for tribes and rebellious factions or else adapted to describe a state-building project. The next chapter of the Turkmen saga conveys a tribal perspective which is found, surprisingly, in the 19th-century manuscripts of a storytelling tradition from the borderlands between the Ottoman Empire and Qājār Iran. A version of the epic of *Köroğlu* (Tur. "the blind man's son") involves a Turkmen hero who weathers the consequences of the imperial expansions in the region.[61] This source suggests the survival and growth of a Turkmen political identity in the post-Aq Quyūnlū context by portraying Turkmen power as a form of resistance to Ottoman and Safavid hegemony.

The story of Köroğlu is a living oral tradition of song and prose that stretches from the Balkans to Central Asia and is usually referred to as an epic or *destan* in Turkish. Originally circulated by minstrels (Tur. *aşık,* Az. *aşıq*) in the Ottoman period, the hero became a symbol for Turkic masculinity and cultural unity in the 19th and 20th centuries in Turkey, Azerbaijan, and Central Asia. In the epic, Köroğlu is a youth whose family is oppressed by political leaders who resorts to banditry against the wealthy and powerful with the aid of his magical horse, Ḳirāt ("the grey horse"), and his band of courageous followers. This basic political theme has myriad regional iterations, one of which is centered on the former Aq Quyūnlū realms of western Iran and the Caucasus, which scholars today frequently call the Caucasus or Azerbaijan version. This version depicts Köroğlu as a "Turkmen" Iranian bandit who terrorizes Ottoman officials and lands, but whose identity has strong Anatolian, Iranian, and Central Asian elements. The earliest prose sources we have for the Caucasus version of the epic are three 19th-century manuscripts in Persian, Turkish, and Armeno-Turkish.[62]

The epic is set at some time between the late 16th and late 17th centuries. The most obvious historical reference is Köroğlu himself, who according to the

61 Different transliterations of his name can be found, including Koroğlu and Kūrūghlī, which reflect regional and linguistic variations. For simplicity and consistency, I have chosen the common modern Turkish spelling.

62 The earliest is a 13-episode Persian text from 1834 penned by Sādeq Beg in northern Iran entitled *The Book of Köroğlu* (Bibliothèque nationale de France, Supplément persan 994, 1r-156v), for which I follow the pagination in red from the original manuscript; the second is an anonymous 28-episode Turkish Azarbāyjānī text from mid-19th century Tabriz entitled "The Book of Celali Köroğlu," of which I cite a modern transliteration (Anonymous, *Azerbaycan Folklor Külliyatı* (2010)); the third is a shorter anonymous Armeno-Turkish version of the famous Bolī Beg episode written in 1881 in Yerevan and entitled "Köroğlu's tale" (Matenadaran, MS 7318, 105v-119v).

archival sources was active in the late 16th century across Anatolia.[63] One manuscript refers to him as "of the sons of the Celālī," reinforcing the connection to this historical setting by alluding to the Celali movements of the same period.[64] A rival-turned-follower of Köroğlu in the stories called Deli Hasan ("Crazy Hasan") shares a name with the brother and successor of the infamous Celālī rebel, Kara Yazıcı (d.1602).[65] The Ottoman Sultan Mūrād (most likely IV, r.1623–1640, potentially III, r.1574–1596)[66] and the Safavid Shāh ʿAbbās I (r.1588–1629) and Shāh ʿAbbās II (r.1642–1666) are also mainstays of the plot.[67] The first translator of the epic into English in the 19th century, Alexander Chodzko, believed Köroğlu to be a 17th-century historical figure based on his ethnographic work with Iranian and Caucasian performers.[68]

A studied approach to oral tradition and our knowledge of the epic at hand suggests that the text is more useful for understanding the 17th-century context it depicts than the 19th-century context in which it was produced. This contradicts the orthodox historical methodology which maintains that a source can only provide a reliable description of the era in which it was written, and as such always offers a biased portrayal of the past. Such healthy skepticism is warranted, but does not account for how oral tradition differs from written tradition in both the timing of production and the preservation of the text over time. In oral storytelling, the date of the formation of a tradition nearly always pre-dates the time of writing, and in the case of Köroğlu, I will demonstrate that we can reasonably locate the former in the 17th century. This does not mean that the tradition remained unchanged thereafter, but it creates the strong likelihood of the retention of an important historical kernel from the earlier era which significantly impacts our understanding of the history of the Turkmen identity.

Walter Ong's classic work on oral cultures describes how storytelling relies on episodic structure with high levels of formulaic repetition, a characteristic which is central to the Köroğlu tradition and all oral epics.[69] We should not approach the epic as a conventional written source because plot details are frequently flourishes with no historical significance. More useful is a historically contextu-

63 For a thorough overview of the various theories about Köroğlu's historic origins as they developed over the 19th and 20th centuries, see Boratav 1978, 911–912.

64 Matenadaran, MS 7318, 105v; He is also called "Celali Köroğlu," Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 1, 110, 231; *Ibid*., XVI: 91.

65 Akdağ 2018, 353–356.

66 Bibliothèque nationale 994, 38r, 38v, 39v, 45v, 46r, 48r, 49r, 55v, 57v, 61v.

67 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 52, 338; Bibliothèque nationale 994, 151v.

68 Chodzko 1842, 3.

69 Ong 2012, 138.

alized analysis of the elements found in the hardened structure of the tradition, especially song, verse, and other elements such as the people and place names which are the skeleton for the plot. These had to be intelligible to live audiences per force, or a performer would do a poor job (a constraint which writers do not face). The historical value of an oral epic tradition, then, depends on our ability to identify the original historical context in which the tradition was formed.

Evidence points to the existence of this type of fully formed, song based Köroğlu tradition by the 17th century. Arak'el of Tabriz referenced the tradition of Köroğlu songs and storytellers in 1660, while Evlīyā Çelebī mentions Köroğlu both as a bandit and as a musician shortly thereafter.[70] Several references in 17th-century Ottoman poetry to two of the main protagonists of the story, Köroğlu and Eyvāz/Ayvāz, confirm how widely known they had become by that time.[71] A 1721 songbook from Tabriz including Köroğlu songs also shows that major elements in the tradition had hardened over a century before the earliest prose manuscripts.[72]

Consequently, as one would expect from an earlier consolidation in the oral realm, the tradition had become remarkably widespread and well-elaborated by the 1800s. When Chodzko recorded the story in Northern Iran and Aẕarbāyjān in the 1820s and 1830s, he wrote that "notwithstanding some differences in the narratives of various Ausheks and Kurroglou-Khans [sic], they all agreed in their substance; and that the improvisations [i. e. songs] of Kurroglu especially, were everywhere the same."[73] Russian journals from the mid-19th century also confirm the ubiquity of the story and the performers who spread it.[74] Indeed, near identical verses are found in the two earliest manuscripts, texts which were produced decades apart, in different circumstances, and by different performers.[75]

Given what we know about the historical origins of its protagonist and the indications of oral circulation in the 17th century, it is implausible that the con-

70 Aṛak'el, *Book* (2010), 91; For the original Armenian, see Aṛak'el, *Patmut'iwn* (1884), 61; Evliya, *Evliya* (2006), book 5, 12; *Ibid*., book 5, 143.

71 Boratav 1984, 112.

72 Azerbaycan Milli Elmlər Akademiyası, Nizami adına Ədəbiyyat İnstitutu elmi arxiv, no. 608.

73 Chodzko 1842, 14. "Aushek" and "Kurroglu-Khan" refer to *aşık*/*aşıq*, or minstrels and professional storytellers.

74 V. 1846, 153, describes Köroğlu as a tradition in Turkey, Persia, and the Caucasus "...sung and told even today, with greater or lesser changes and variations, and always with animation and delight, by shared listeners"; Anonymous 1853, 233, "The name of Köroğlu is famous in all of the Trans-Caucasus..."; Anonymous 1856, 83, "...there is no corner of Asia or the East more generally where [Köroğlu's] name has not been renowned. You will even hear it in Bessarabia and Moldova...Turks and Persians dispute for the right to call him their own compatriot."

75 Here one can compare, for instance, Bibliothèque nationale 994, 31v, and Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 63, for the verse about Ayvaz (starting, *bāşīna dūndūkūm, ḳurbān ūldūḳūm*...)

tents of such a widespread, professionalized, and internally coherent storytelling tradition underwent a significant overhaul from a 19th-century perspective. Nor is there any evidence in the text to support the theory of later interventions. An argument for nostalgia among 19th-century borderland tribes may be entertained, but their choice of a band of thieves to represent the past would require explanation. Based on our understanding of oral tradition and the historical context of the region, we must accept that the text transmits a significant kernel from the 17th-century context.

We should begin by asking why the Köroğlu tradition glorified a Turkmen hero. Although he is attributed this identity in some other versions of the epic, the meaning of the label changed according to the region in which it was performed. (For instance, in versions circulating in Turkmenistan, Köroğlu belongs to the regionally distinct Central Asian Turkmen population.) All three early manuscripts of the Caucasus version call the protagonist a Turkmen; two of them make note of this in the first line of the text, and the third does so in the first line of the hero's origin story.[76]

Despite this foregrounding, the meaning of the label is not immediately apparent. On occasion, it functions to distinguish the protagonist from both his imperial Ottoman and Safavid rivals. For instance, the Safavid ruler Shāh ʿAbbās II orders his men to attack Köroğlu, saying, "...Don't let this Turkmen kid get away!"[77] The Ottoman and Safavid characters use the term in a pejorative sense, and it seems that this was mainly owing to its enduring tribal connotation. As Köroğlu explains to the servant of an outsider passing through his home base of Çamlıbel, "We are tribes (*īlāt*), and our settlement (*ūbā*) is just on the other side of the mountain."[78] In the Tabriz manuscript, the narrator also specifies how Köroğlu's family lived in "the city of Mazanderan" in the winter but moved to their tribal pastures for the summer (*yaylāq*).[79]

Koroğlu is also given specific tribal affiliations, reinforcing this aspect of the Turkmen label. In two of the sources, he is identified as a member of the Teke tribe, both a suggestive and a confounding term. On the one hand, tribes and states by this name can be found in Anatolian, Iranian, and Central Asian history.[80] On the other hand, in the 17th-century Caucasus context, the term would

76 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 49.

77 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 84–85.

78 Bibliothèque nationale 994, 63r.

79 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 51.

80 One group of Teke, which were found along the Caspian Sea coast in Central Asia, eventually came into contact with Safavid Iran during the 16th and 17th centuries (Sümer 1980, 139, 334). Far to the west, another tribe known as the Tekeoğulları established a principality on the Mediterranean coast during the 13th and 14th centuries. Members of this group later joined the early

have likely evoked the memory of the Teke tribe which participated in the early Safavid movement and was later anointed as one of the core components of the empire's *Qezelbāsh* base and thus would have carried tribal military prestige.

The text, however, plays with geography. The manuscripts are littered with references to Köroğlu's geographic origins, which consistently fall between Anatolia and Central Asia. In the Sadeq Beg text, the bandit's origins lie in *Turkestān*, or Turkish-speaking Central Asia.[81] In the Tabriz manuscript, the narrator explains that the Turkmen federation was originally from Anatolia (*Rūm vilāyatī*), but that over time, Safavid rulers had relocated the "Celali tribe" from Anatolia to northeastern Iran near the cities of Merv, Herat, and Shāh Jahan, rendering both Anatolia and Central Asia possible points of origin.[82] In the Tabriz manuscript, Köroğlu twice declares that, "My origins go back to the Teke, Turkmen, Yomut," adding the Yomut, a tribe found only along the eastern Caspian coast, to the mix, giving more credence to the notion of Central Asian origins.[83] To make things more baffling, all three texts also describe the protagonist and his men as Iranian (*ʿacem oğlū*).[84]

Despite a multi-polar and at times contradictory geography, the text reinforces the notion that "Turkmen" was still primarily a term implying tribal autonomy and military strength, but one which did not have a geographic anchor. This flexibility allowed storytellers to attribute Köroğlu origins in Anatolia, Iran, or Central Asia. Thus far, the term's meaning in the epic was still roughly consistent with its usage in the period preceding Ottoman and Safavid hegemony. The text's interplay between Anatolia and Central Asia may even mirror the Aq Quyūnlū 's simultaneous ownership of a political Turkmen identity and a mythical Oghuz identity, and also serves to capture the historical range of movement of the Oghuz Turks. For *aşıq*s (bards) who performed the story, geographic options may have been in short supply, making "Iran" the most convenient narrative solution for the homeland of the charismatic Turkmen protagonist who was a sworn enemy of the Ottomans.

The chief new insight which the epic offers regards the political nature of this Turkmen identity. Köroğlu has a deep disdain for the bureaucratic empires that flank him on either side. He is unequivocally against Ottoman power ("I will not

Safavid coalition which fought the expansion of Ottoman power in Anatolia. They came to be referred to as the Tekelu, or *Takallū* in Persian (Kofoğlu 2011, 348–350).

81 Bibliothèque nationale 994, 1v.

82 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 49.

83 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 224; *Ibid.*, XVI: 85.

84 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 15, 88; Matenadaran, MS 7318, 116v; Bibliothèque nationale 994, 146v.

go to that Sultan!" i. e., negotiate with him),[85] and also has plenty of ire for the empire's institutions with which he regularly contends ("I have made Janissaries' heads roll!").[86] Fighting and killing Ottoman individuals and higher-ups, especially *pāşā*s and *vāli*s (governors), is a routine part of his exploits.

The anti-Ottoman pattern explains why Rūm, the common regional term for former Byzantine lands under Ottoman power, looms so large as an arena of battle and settling old scores. As implied by the moniker "The ruler of Rūm" (*Rūm Xondkārī*), Rūm signified Ottoman space in the epic.[87] In one episode, Köroğlu unwittingly breaks into song while sneaking through the Ottoman palace, and then chastises himself, "You were singing like a nightingale in the middle of the seven walls of the harem of Sultan Murad the Ottoman Padishah…[here] all of the inhabitants of Rūm are your enemy!"[88] His words draw a direct connection between the Ottoman state represented by the person of the sultan and the inhabitants of Rūm. Similarly, Ottoman officials in an episode from the Tabriz manuscript discuss the need to protect "the Ottoman dynastic state and all of the inhabitants of Rūm" from the predations of the infamous warrior.[89]

But the bandit's wrath is not only directed at the Ottomans and the inhabitants of Rūm. When he sings, "I don't trust wealth, or the power of states/All I have are my Teke Turkmen mates!" (*Küvenmerem mülk ü māl ü dövlete/Ḳāldī menim Teke Türkmān ellerim*), he implies that Turkmen tribes represent freedom from the heavy hand of rulers everywhere.[90] He regards the Safavids as erstwhile friends who now perpetuate the cruelty and mistreatment that he associates with Ottoman-style top-down rule. His blinded father's reprimand of Shāh ʿAbbās II (r.1642–1666) describes the family's misgivings about Safavid power: "I had heard that the rulers of the Safavid house were just, but you treated me unjustly for no good reason and you blinded me, from now on I will never heed your words and put myself in danger again."[91] In the Tabriz manuscript, this new brand of Safavid rule was characterized by harsh taxation and heavy-handed interference with tribal autonomy.[92] This also gives new meaning to the recurring Teke tribal affiliation, since this tribe was violently dispersed in 1530 by a Safavid coalition after accumulating too much power in the imperial administration.[93]

85 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 43.
86 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 230.
87 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 243.
88 Bibliothèque nationale 994, 56v.
89 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XV: 231.
90 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 353.
91 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 61.
92 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 52–53.
93 Gündüz 2018.

Another feature which Köroğlu shares with the early Safavid movement is his devotion to ʿAlī. While the epic lacks discourse on spiritual practice and on Islam, Sunnī, Shīʿa, or otherwise, it demonstrates what can be called strong Alid leanings. Köroğlu frequently makes declarations such as, "I am ready and committed to Imam ʿAlī."[94] This reinforces a connection to the cultural context of 15th-century Anatolia and a mode of religiosity which pre-dated the Safavid state's shift to institutionalized Twelver Shiʿism. The Köroğlu epic may contain echoes of voices from the original Safavid coalition cloaked in a Turkmen identity, a lingering perspective which would explain the unfavorable treatment of the dynasty in the tradition.

Conclusions

This essay has offered an introductory overview to the use of the term *Turkmen* in Ottoman and Safavid lands chiefly from the 15th to the 17th centuries. We can see by the range of ways in which the label was deployed that at its root lay a contradictory notion of power. It evoked tribal autonomy but could also bolster the political ideology of centralized states. The post-Mongol Turkmen identity stretched at least from the Euphrates River to Aẕarbāyjān across a geography that some scholars would consider imperial borderlands, although Köroğlu would not have marginalized himself with such language. Here, Turkmen power may have possessed a popular legitimacy which rivaled that of the bureaucratic powers of Istanbul and Isfahan.

The overuse of an urban "Islam"-oriented lens in the study of Turkish history has made it easy for scholars to assume that the term *Turkmen* always indicated marginal or truculent tribes, a widely understood connotation which it maintained throughout the Ottoman and Safavid periods. State perspectives will frequently confirm this meaning, whereas popular sources such as the Köroğlu epic and unofficial voices such as those of Evlīyā Çelebī or Arak'el of Tabriz tell a more complicated story. The Köroğlu tradition is most provocative in its reclamation of the Turkmen identity from an anti-state perspective, in contrast to its cooptation by the Aq Quyūnlū for a state-building project. Both, however, represented alternative political visions to Ottoman and Safavid imperial rule which drew upon tribal power for legitimacy.

94 Anonymous, *Azerbaycan* (2010), XVI: 73. For other Alid utterances in the text: *Ibid*., XV: 66, 91, 110, 219, 321; *Ibid*., XVI: 72, 165, 271, 344; Bibliothèque nationale 994, 32v, 77v, 93r, 94r.

This topic presents opportunities for further study; one is a more detailed look at the 15th-century sources across Anatolia and Iran, including Ottoman, Shirvānshāh, Mamlūk, and Timurid texts, to more closely analyze the impact of the rise of the Turkmen dynasties on the usage of the term. Another is a thorough analysis of the relationship between Turkmen identity and resistance to Ottoman power. In the 19th century, the popular bard Dadaloğlu wrote that, "When the decree from the Sovereign of Persia crosses Turkmen lands (*Türkmen ili*)/O! Is there any safety for the Ottoman dynasty?," referring to the rebellious Turkmen tribes in his homeland east of the Tarsus Mountains.[95] As this essay's analysis of the Köroğlu tradition suggests, popular culture may be a realm where historians can access such subversive voices.

Part of the Turkmen label's power must have derived from its generic nature, as it could describe most Turkish speaking tribes in Ottoman and Safavid realms. It should not come as a surprise that historians have yet to fully understand the significance of a label which represented an anti-imperial ethos and was also a typical label for bothersome tribes from the perspective of the state.

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95 Köprülü 2004, 613.

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